

Deep Dive: How to Have Difficult Conversations

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The second part of communicating at work is knowing how to have difficult conversations. That's right – conversations that make your heart race a little faster, the ones that you might be dreading. You might be thinking of some examples right now.

I know in my own career, I have had to have some very difficult conversations. At one point, I even had to dismiss an underperforming team member that had helped to hire and train me, and who I considered a friend. Talk about a difficult conversation.

As a woman in leadership or a future leader, difficult conversations come with the territory. The key is to learn how to master them, or at least not be afraid of them. Because when we put off the thing that needs to be said, or the conversation that should have been had with a team member four weeks ago, everyone loses. So here are some things to keep in mind.

First, don't put it off. The harder the conversation is, the less you want to put it off. Hard things only get more difficult with time, not easier. Pat once said "When something unpleasant happens between two members of our team, I don't believe in burying it. I ask the two players to confront each other and settle it."

Before initiating the conversation, make sure you can clearly articulate the main issue. There may be several details or general things to address, but what are the 2-3 main things, "We can't leave this room until this is squared away."

You also want to keep the discussion rooted in the facts. Instead of "You're underperforming," which could be seen as subjective, try "Our revenue numbers are down due to lack of sales," or "The new product isn't doing as well as we need it to," instead of "You rolled this product out too quickly."

Facts help ground the conversation in reality and reduce emotional responses. If you're having a conversation with your leader about a new role with new job duties, for example, what are the 2-3 main things you need to make sure they understand?

Before having the conversation, make sure you pick the right time and place. This usually means in private, not public, and at a time when it's convenient for both parties. Ever had someone who gave you some difficult news at 8 a.m. in the morning and you had to walk back to your desk and pretend nothing had happened? How about a Friday afternoon at 5 p.m., right when you were about to walk out the door for the weekend? Having a

conversation with the finance team about hiring more people on the last week of the month when they're trying to reconcile the numbers probably *isn't* the best timing. Nor is having an important conversation in the middle of a crowded place, or within earshot of others.

You also want to approach the conversation with a constructive mindset. Aim for a *collaborative* discussion, not a confrontational one. If there is a desired outcome or change that needs to happen from the conversation, you want to disarm the other person as much as possible from putting up their defenses or thinking their beliefs are under attack.

That being said, be specific and direct. There's an old saying "To be unclear is to be unkind." You want to clearly articulate the issue without beating around the bush. Don't retreat to the safety of generalizations.

Remember, this is a *conversation*. You want to make sure that you *listen* and leave time for the other person to share their perspective. Listen without interrupting and try to acknowledge their feelings and viewpoints. "I know you really like Sheila, but the fact is, her work is below the standard of what we usually accept." Or "I can see where you feel the new department merger is unfair. But we're counting on you to help make this work."

Do your best to stay calm and composed throughout the conversation. If emotions run high, take a break. Try to avoid escalating any emotions that may be present.

After everything has been discussed and you've listened to the other person's perspective, you want to shift the focus from the problem to finding solutions. Collaborate with the other person to identify steps to address the issue. At the end of the conversation, summarize the key points discussed and the agreed-upon action items. This ensures that both parties have a clear understanding of the outcomes and next steps.

Now, those are some principles to consider in general for difficult conversations. If you're going to be delivering feedback as part of this conversation, maybe as in a 1:1 with a team member, here are some things to keep in mind.

Slow down. Let them know your heart. Provide feedback in context of your belief in that person. "I know you're capable of more than this," or "I've seen you perform better than this in the past." Frame your concerns from your own perspective using "I" statements. For example, say "I've noticed that deadlines are often missed, and I'm concerned about the impact on our projects" instead of "You always miss deadlines."

Don't speak for people who aren't in the conversation, unless you have their permission. That isn't fair to the other person and robs them of the opportunity to communicate in their

own way, in addition to making the person on the other end of the conversation feel like they are being ganged up on. You're sharing other people's opinions and feelings, but the only person they have to discuss them with is you.

Finally, go slow, and give them time to process. Have them repeat back to you what they've heard, in order to make sure both of you are on the same page with what the next steps need to be.

Now, I know that's a lot, but with some time and practice, difficult conversations won't be so difficult. As a leader or future leader, you want to know how to communicate in the best way, even in the worst of times or circumstances.